national strengths. It grew to a level where Russia's role, then as the USSR, was critical to a strategic inflection point in the Indian subcontinent in 1971.

The resulting goodwill, combined with a continuing sensitivity to India's interests, has kept these ties steady despite global tumult. Even the break-up of the USSR had limited impact, with the two nations re-discovering their mutual priority within a decade.

Today, it is this Indian relationship with Russia that is most on the global radar. In terms of significance, it compares in many respects to that with the US and China. Its economic content may be less, but for India, it has enormous strategic and security relevance. The unintended consequences of an unforeseen conflict, however, have paradoxically hastened some possibilities long under discussion. As a result, Russia could well emerge as a primary supplier of resources at the very time that India ramps up its economic growth and expands such needs.

The irony today about the partnership is that it is the subject of attention not because it has changed but because it has not. In fact, ties between Russia and India have been among the steadiest of the major relationships in the world after the Second World War. Each country has seen ups and downs in its ties with many other partners. Yet, for a variety of reasons, both have managed to insulate their own relationship from the volatility of global events. It appears that the logic of geopolitics combined with the mutuality of benefits have provided an exceptionally strong ballast to their ties.

If relations have been stable, this is not to say that either nation has remained static as a polity or even as a society. In the last quarter of a century, India has grown to emerge as the fifth largest economy, a nuclear weapon power, a technology centre, a reservoir of global talent and an active shaper of international debates. Its interests and influence have grown well beyond the Subcontinent.

Russia has, meanwhile, defined itself more nationally, with the accompanying changes in orientation and priorities. Its inherent character as a Eurasian power and its global status make it salient to the world order. Russia has also demonstrated an ability to influence outcomes across regions and issues. Its importance in domains like energy, resources and technology remains noteworthy.

The last three decades have seen the autonomous evolution of both Russia and India. They may have forged partnerships with others that may